appearance of having languished ‘in exile, barbarized by misuse’. The vocabulary suggests an absence of hybridization and dilution with local accents and usages. It is—

> a language full of vitality, aware of contemporary usage, skilled in the handling of the literary language, familiar with the terms used by philosophers and sophists, as well as those found in the vocabulary of politics, able to find the closest equivalents to specifically Indian concepts such as *eusebeia* for the notion of *dhamma*, *diatribe* which means ‘school of philosophy’ in Greek for *pasamda*, the Indian term for religious sect, and *enkrateia*, the Greek expression for self-control, which applies to the restraint which the emperor’s subjects must practice among themselves.[26]

Clearly, the scribe’s skills in Greek were fairly advanced. The Greek edict does not seem like a translation of general statements unspecific to locality either. On the contrary, care seems to have been taken to adapt the ruler’s voice to a form locally appropriate and comprehensible. Mortimer Wheeler had such elements of Greek culture in mind when remarking that at Kandahar ‘we need then no longer to hesitate to accept a full-blown “Alexandria” upon the side of Old Kandahar. This was no mere tired vestige of a passing army. It was a balanced Greek city with its writers, its philosophers, its teachers, no less than its executives and its growing environment of Hellenized “natives”’.[27]

Setting aside the encomia for a moment and looking at possible problems in the wording, it would seem that in the third century BCE the precise terminology required in Greek for Buddhist concepts will have involved something of a wrestle because of the lack of exact equivalents. The deployment here of the Greek ‘eusebeia’ or piety is an example. The intention is to introduce the idea of dhamma, but in fact the Greek word is something of a far cry from the Ashokan notion of dhamma.[28] Eusebeia apparently ‘defines a respect or awe by humans towards the gods or other divine beings; it applies much less to interactions between mortals themselves.’[29] It also involves the idea of sacrifice, which in the Greek context meant killing animals. This would make it most contradictory to